Testing a Famous Political Proxy: Whole Foods vs. Cracker Barrel

The metric replicates to within a point, and then does not survive being asked about people

Democracy's Data

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In September 2011 David Wasserman stood in the Cracker Barrel in Manassas, Virginia, then drove twenty-six miles east to the Whole Foods in Clarendon. The column he wrote for the *Washington Post* proposed that the coming election would be fought between those two parking lots. It carried a number quoted ever since:

> In 2008, candidate Barack Obama carried 81 percent of counties with a Whole Foods and just 36 percent of counties with a Cracker Barrel — a record 45-point gap.

Fifteen years later the shorthand is a fixture of election-night commentary. It says you can read a county's politics off its grocery stores. Is that true? The question is worth your time because a stand-in like this one is how many people picture the political divide, and one that is wrong in a particular direction moves the picture with it.

01 The test

Answering it takes three files joined together. Store locations for both chains, from OpenStreetMap on 14 August 2026. County presidential returns for 2008 through 2024, from Tony McGovern's compilation. And the Census Bureau's county boundaries, populations and area, with a Department of Agriculture count of college-educated adults.

The returns and census tables are the easy half. **The store list is the problem: neither company publishes where its stores are.** Cracker Barrel is a public company, so it files a count: 657 stores in 43 states as of 12 September 2025. A count is not a list, and carries no addresses. Whole Foods has been an Amazon subsidiary since 2017 and files nothing about itself, so the number of its markets in the country is not a published figure at all.

So the inventory here is OpenStreetMap, searched for every United States object carrying the brand's Wikidata identifier: 532 Whole Foods Markets and 647 Cracker Barrels, mapped by volunteers. The independent half of a famous political metric is a crowd-sourced guess at a private fact.

The join turns three files into one table. Each store is placed inside a county polygon, which hands it a five-digit county code, and that code is the column the returns and census tables also carry. Join Keys and Crosswalks states the rule this section keeps returning to, and explains the crosswalk, a table that translates one set of areas into another. A number built from two sources inherits the assumptions of both, and the join adds one about how they line up. Here that assumption is that a county code means the same ground in the store file and in every year's returns. It does not.

02 The data

The build writes one row per county. `counties.csv` carries `has_wf` and `has_cb`, the four-way `cat` combining them, then `pop`, `land_sqmi`, `density`, `ba_pct`, and `win`, `dem`, `gop`, `total` per election. `gap.csv` reduces that to one row per election, with `wf_counties`, `cb_counties`, `wf_votes`, `cb_votes`, `gap_counties` and `gap_votes`. `categories.csv` reduces it the other way, one row per store category, with `county_share`, `vote_share`, `dem_counties_pct`, `dem_votes_pct`, `med_pop`, `med_density` and `med_ba`.

Stores are matched on the brand's Wikidata identifier rather than on the name. Names are typed by hand by thousands of people, as *Whole Foods*, *Whole Foods Market* or *Whole-Foods*, and a name match drops whichever spellings nobody anticipated.

Only one brand can be audited, which is itself a finding. Against Cracker Barrel's own filing the volunteer map holds up: 647 of 657 stores, 98.5%. The state count does not. The map places Cracker Barrels in 44 states and the company says 43, and the difference is one restaurant: Maine's only Cracker Barrel closed in January 2025 and is still mapped. Nothing equivalent can be done for Whole Foods, because there is no filing to check.

Four cleaning decisions follow, and each changed a published number.

Connecticut is two different maps. The state replaced its counties with nine planning regions; the 2024 returns use the new shapes and the four earlier elections the old ones. Uncorrected, this file showed no Whole Foods county in Connecticut until 2024, and there were four. Stores are now assigned twice, once per vintage.

Washington is eight rows in 2024 and one before it. The compilation reports the District by ward, and no boundary file contains wards, so its 8 Whole Foods are summed back into one row. **Shannon County, South Dakota, does not exist**: renamed Oglala Lakota in 2015 and given a new code, it leaves a naive panel carrying two rows for one place. **And Alaska has no counties at all**, reporting votes by State House district, so every share here is of fifty jurisdictions rather than fifty-one. Each of these fails quietly, because a missing match produces a zero and a zero is a valid store count.

> **Before you read on, commit to two numbers.** In 2024 the Democratic candidate carried some share of counties containing a Whole Foods and some share of counties containing a Cracker Barrel. **How many percentage points apart are those two shares?** Now ask the same question of *people*: take every vote cast in Whole Foods counties and every vote cast in Cracker Barrel counties, and take the Democratic share of each. **How many points apart are those?** Write both down.

03 What it says about democracy

Start with whether the metric can be reproduced. This store list was captured in August 2026; Wasserman's 2020 figures came from one five and a half years older. Recomputing his four categories:

Counties with	How many	Wasserman published	This file recomputes	Difference
whole foods only	95	95%	94.7%	-0.3
both	116	77%	75.9%	-1.1
cracker barrel only	363	18%	17.4%	-0.6
neither	2538	12%	11.7%	-0.3

Every category lands within about a point. The same holds further back: for 2008 the column reports a 45-point gap and this file recomputes 43.3 points, a drift of 1.7 across fifteen years of openings and closings. **So nothing that follows can be blamed on the data.**

2024, measured in	Whole Foods counties	Cracker Barrel counties	Gap
counties carried	76.9%	26.5%	50.4 points
votes cast	59.4%	48.6%	10.8 points

Measured the way the metric is always measured, one county and one tally, the divide is enormous and has grown: 43 points in 2008 and 50 in 2024. Measured in people, the same counties are 10.8 points apart, and that number has barely moved in sixteen years.

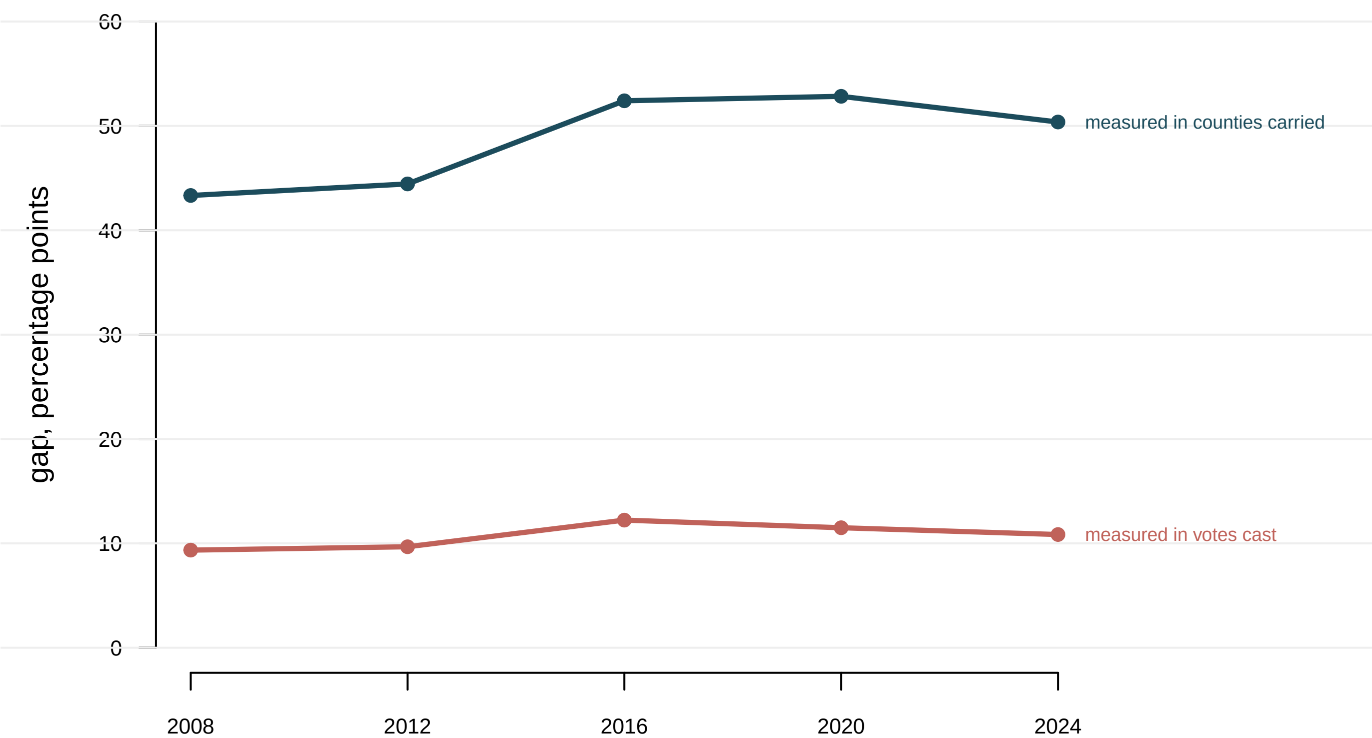

Figure 1. The same metric on two units. Both readings are drawn on one axis, because the claim under test is a distance, and a distance split across two panels is one the reader

will not measure. The upper line is the published version, the share of *counties* carried. The lower line is the same counties, elections and stores, with the Democratic share of the two-party vote in place of the count of counties.

Nothing was done to the data between the two lines. The disagreement comes from a fact about American counties the metric's arithmetic assumes away.

Counties with	How many	Share of all counties	D carried	Share of all votes	D share of votes
whole foods only	96	3.1%	90.6%	24.1%	65.5%
both	116	3.7%	65.5%	27.8%	54.2%
cracker barrel only	363	11.6%	14.0%	17.9%	39.9%
neither	2,546	81.6%	9.4%	30.2%	37.4%

The first reason is a category. **The counties with neither store are 82% of all counties and 30% of all votes.** They are the largest block of the electorate and the most Republican group in the table, and the metric has no column for them. Whatever the gap measures, it measures on the 18% of counties where one of two companies opened.

The second reason is the definition. Wasserman's own rule is that a county with both stores counts in both columns, which is nearly harmless for 116 counties out of 3,121 when the unit is counties. It is not harmless when the unit is votes: those counties are the big metros, they cast 28% of the national vote, and they appear at full weight on *both* sides of the subtraction. Take the overlap out and the exclusive categories are 65.5% to 39.9%, a 25.6-point gap. That is a real and large difference, describing 42% of the electorate rather than all of it.

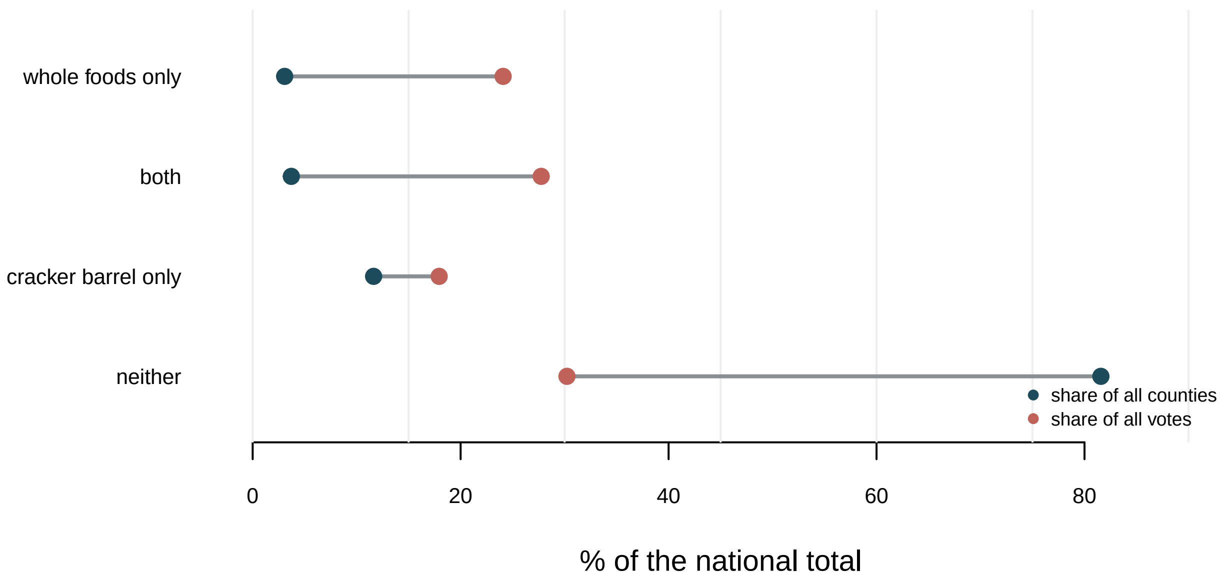

Figure 2. Counties are not people. Each category carries two shares, one of counties and one of votes, and the bar between them is the distance the metric ignores. Cracker Barrel counties are 12% of counties and 18% of votes; Whole Foods counties are the reverse.

The folk reading of the metric is that Whole Foods stands for the urban professional and Cracker Barrel for rural America. The first half is right and the second is wrong. **A median**

Cracker Barrel county holds 172,069 people; a median county with neither store holds 19,722. Cracker Barrels sit on interstate exits outside regional towns, where the traffic is, so Cracker Barrel country is the middle of American county size rather than the bottom. Rural America is the 2,546 counties with neither store, and it is the more Republican: the Democratic candidate carried 9.4% of them against 14.0% of Cracker Barrel counties.

One question is left. The metric feels like a reading of culture, but a cheaper explanation is available: Whole Foods opens where there are dense, affluent, highly educated customers, and those are the people who vote Democratic. Take the 212 counties selected by "has a Whole Foods", then the same number selected by rules using no store data, and ask each the identical question.

The 212 counties picked by	D carried	D share of their votes	That also have a Whole Foods
has a Whole Foods	76.9%	59.4%	100%
the 212 densest counties	74.5%	59.9%	64%
the 212 most-educated counties	71.7%	61.5%	50%
the 212 most populous counties	63.7%	57.5%	74%

On counties the store list wins by about two points. On votes it loses. Density and education each pick a set of counties whose electorate is *more* Democratic than the Whole Foods set. The last column shows why the contest is close: 64% of the densest 212 counties already contain a Whole Foods. The store list is substantially a density list with a brand name on it.

Cracker Barrel's spokeswoman told Wasserman in 2011 that "politics don't play any role in our site selection process." She was right, and that is the problem. The stores are sited on traffic counts, rooftops and household income, which is why they line up with the vote and why they add so little once you have the rooftops.

04 What this brief cannot tell you

It cannot tell you that the store list is complete. It is a volunteer file audited against one company's filing and against nothing for the other. 98.5% coverage is reassuring, but no guarantee that the missing 10 are scattered at random. If volunteers map less thoroughly where fewer volunteers live, the gaps sit where the metric is most sensitive.

The matched-count test is a comparison, not a regression, meaning not a best line drawn through a scatter of points. That density picks a similar set of counties does not prove the store adds nothing, only that whatever it adds is small.

A store is not a shopper. Every claim here is about counties containing a store, never about people who shop in one. Wasserman's headline was about shoppers; his data, like this data, was about county boundaries. This book makes that argument at length in levels-of-aggregation.

And it says nothing about 2028. Every figure here is retrospective, and the bellwether brief is the warning about pointing a county-level regularity at the future.

05 What you should have learned

- The proxy replicates. Rebuilt from a volunteer store list captured fifteen years later, Wasserman's four 2020 categories land within about a point, and the 2008 gap drifts by 1.7 points.
- The same metric gives 50 points measured in counties carried and 10.8 measured in votes cast, from one file in one year.
- Counties are not people. The 2,546 counties with neither store are 82% of counties and 30% of votes, and the metric has no column for them.
- Cracker Barrel country is not rural: its median county holds 172,069 people against 19,722 where there is no store at all.
- A proxy is worth only what it adds to the ordinary numbers it stands for, and 64% of the densest 212 counties already contain a Whole Foods.

06 Extensions

Each can be answered by sorting or grouping in a spreadsheet, and none is answered above.

- `gap.csv` has `gap_counties` and `gap_votes` for each election. Follow both down the years. Which one is the metric usually quoted as, and which describes the electorate?
- `categories.csv` gives `med_density`, `med_pop` and `med_ba` per category. Sort by `med_pop`. Is Cracker Barrel country actually rural, or only not urban?
- `alternatives.csv` swaps in other rules for picking counties, with `overlap_wf_pct`. Find one that does about as well as the store list. What was the metric really measuring?
- `inventory_check.csv` sets a company filing's `stores` beside `stores_osm` from the open map. Work out the discrepancy, and decide which source you would cite.

Two go past the spreadsheet. Pick another chain with a political reputation and see whether it publishes addresses at all. Or rebuild the four categories in `counties.csv` on the 2020 returns, using `has_wf_2020` and `has_cb_2020`, and say which answer you would print.

07 Sources

Data

- OpenStreetMap contributors. Store locations for Whole Foods Market (`brand:wikidata=Q1809448`) and Cracker Barrel (`brand:wikidata=Q4492609`), all United States objects, retrieved through the Overpass API on 14 August 2026 under the Open Database Licence. The responses are kept, because the same query does not return the same answer twice. https://overpass-api.de/api/interpreter and https://www.openstreetmap.org/
- Cracker Barrel Old Country Store, Inc. *Annual Report on Form 10-K for the fiscal year ended 1 August 2025.* Item 1, store and state counts as of 12 September 2025. https://investor.crackerbarrel.com/static-files/881c3ef3-0a78-4e60-9fc8-6d2a340bdbc8
- McGovern, Tony. *US County Level Presidential Results 2008–2024*, used for all five elections. https://github.com/tonmcg/US_County_Level_Election_Results_08-24

- U.S. Census Bureau. *2024 and 2020 Cartographic Boundary Files*, counties, for the two geographies the elections use; *2024 Gazetteer Files* for land area; *Vintage 2024 Population Estimates*. https://www2.census.gov/geo/tiger/GENZ2024/shp/cb_2024_us_county_500k.zip, https://www2.census.gov/geo/tiger/GENZ2020/shp/cb_2020_us_county_500k.zip, https://www2.census.gov/geo/docs/maps-data/data/gazetteer/2024_Gazetteer/2024_Gaz_counties_national.zip and https://www2.census.gov/programs-surveys/popest/datasets/2020-2024/counties/totals/co-est2024-alldata.csv
- U.S. Department of Agriculture, Economic Research Service. *County-level Data Sets: Education*, adults 25 and over with a degree, 2018–22. https://ers.usda.gov/sites/default/files/_laserfiche/DataFiles/48747/Education.csv
- Wasserman, David. "Will the 2012 election be a contest of Whole Foods vs. Cracker Barrel shoppers?" *Washington Post*, 28 September 2011: the 2008 figures and the spokeswoman's remark. His four-category breakdown of 2020, posted 8 December 2020, is the published column in the replication table. https://www.washingtonpost.com/opinions/will-the-2012-election-be-a-contest-of-whole-foods-vs-cracker-barrel-shoppers/2011/09/27/gIQAJdKA5K_story.html
- Hoey, Dennis. "Maine's only Cracker Barrel closes in South Portland." *Portland Press Herald*, 21 January 2025, on the closure the map still carries. https://www.pressherald.com/2025/01/21/maines-only-cracker-barrel-closes-in-south-portland/

The data itself

The tables this brief rests on are plain CSV and open in a spreadsheet.

`alternatives.csv`, `anachronism.csv`, `categories.csv`, `counties.csv`, `gap.csv`, `inventory_check.csv`, `published_2020.csv`, `stores.csv`

REBUILD THIS DATA YOURSELF, WITH AN AI ASSISTANT

```
I want to rebuild a public dataset from its original source, without
any starting files. Please do the following and show your work — and
know going in that this source is edited by volunteers every day, so
your counts will sit near the ones below, not on them.
THE SOURCE. OpenStreetMap, read through the Overpass API at
https://overpass-api.de/api/interpreter
Free, no account, no key, but rate-limited — be polite and expect a
long query to take a minute. Ask for every United States object whose
brand:wikidata tag is Q1809448 (Whole Foods Market) or Q4492609
(Cracker Barrel). Each object is one mapped store, with coordinates.
Neither company publishes a store list: Cracker Barrel files only a
count with the SEC, and Whole Foods, as an Amazon subsidiary, files
nothing — so a volunteer map is the best public inventory there is,
and that is the point worth noticing.
WHAT TO BUILD.
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1. A count of each chain's mapped stores, and the number of states each appears in.
2. The same counts audited against the one official number that exists: Cracker Barrel's annual report (Form 10-K, fiscal 2025) says how many stores in how many states.
3. Each store placed in its county, using the Census Bureau's county boundary files, and a count of counties containing each chain.

CHECK YOUR WORK. The copy this book used was drawn on 13 August 2026, against a map database current to the day. You should find numbers near these:

- 532 Whole Foods and 647 Cracker Barrel objects
- the 10-K says 657 stores in 43 states; the volunteer map finds Cracker Barrel in 44, because it still carries a Maine store that closed — disagreement of that size is the expected finding
- 212 counties with a Whole Foods, 479 with a Cracker Barrel

OpenStreetMap changes every day; a count a handful off means volunteers edited the map, not that you made an error.